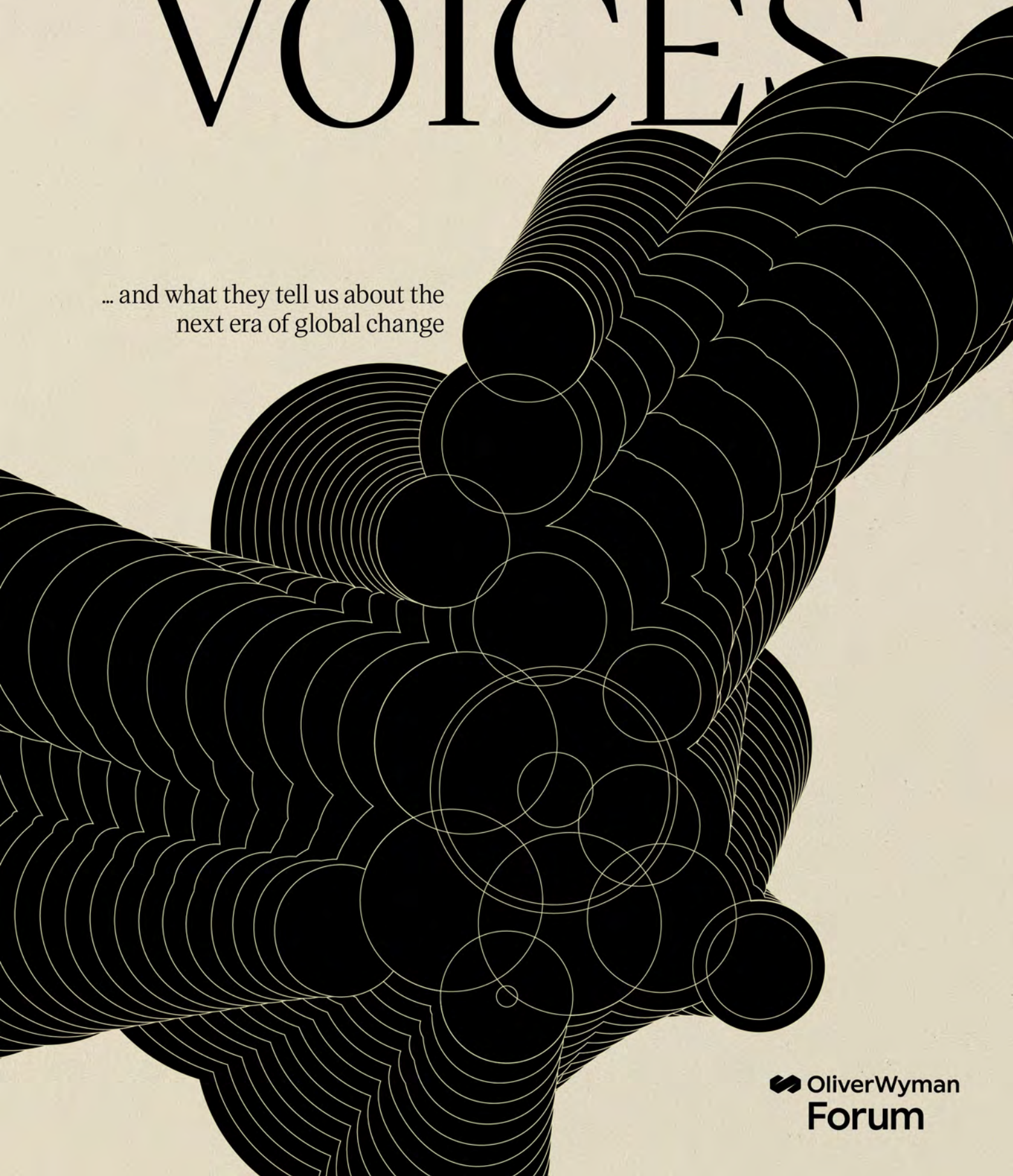


# 300,000 VOICES

... and what they tell us about the  
next era of global change



What 300,000 voices tell us about  
the next era of global change

# Foreword

Historians might disagree about which period of the past century was the most tumultuous, but the 2020s are surely on the shortlist. The global pandemic was just the beginning; social upheaval, geopolitical conflict, economic shocks, and technological advancement have left people unsettled and introspective, focusing their energy on things they can control. They are more concerned with personal fulfillment and less fixated on macro issues, more trusting of smaller communities and less credulous of big institutions, more likely to be thriving but less likely to feel that way than they were at the dawn of this decade.

We know this because they've told us.

Back in 2020, when the world first seemed to wobble off its axis, the Oliver Wyman Forum launched the Global Voices survey to collect insights across a range of topics, from workforce trends to disinformation, to help business and government leaders understand and navigate the changes taking place. We assumed the pandemic would impact society like other shocks of the 20th century, creating a "cohort memory" that would reshape long-term attitudes and beliefs. Our hunch proved correct; the results were so revelatory that we were inspired to keep asking questions.

Now, we have reached a milestone.

At the five-year mark of this project we have amassed almost 300,000 different cuts of opinion, experience, and belief across 20 nations, on a growing range of topics. Some of the results are longitudinal, with responses across all five years. Others reflect new questions being asked to help us get more closely connected with the ever-changing zeitgeist.

At first the data were noisy to the point of cacophony. But as we began to isolate the signal in those 300,000 voices, we found clear evidence of people changing across numerous dimensions, from what they value and how they feel to how they work and lead to how they invest and spend. Much of this change is being driven by a new variable that has quickly taken a central role in business and society: artificial intelligence.

Taken together, these changing social, economic, and personal dynamics are helping to rewrite the rules of business. Leaders who understand the interplay across all of these categories will have a major advantage in the years ahead. We hope you find enlightening the essays and graphics in the pages that follow.

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